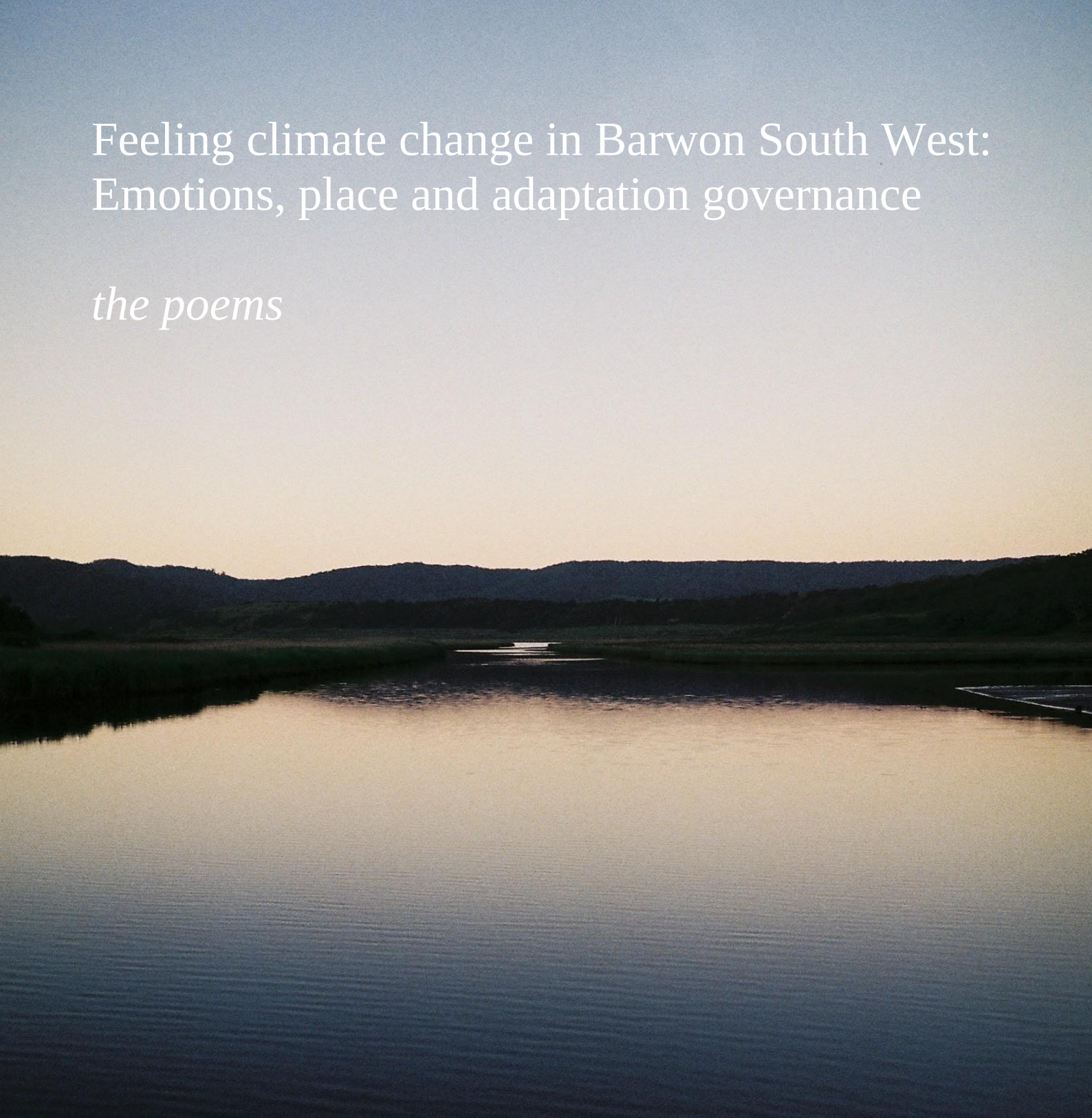
Feeling climate change in Barwon South West: Emotions, place and adaptation governance

the poems



Frances Grimshaw

These poems, and the fieldwork that it is based on, Wurundjeri Woi Wurrung, Wadawurrung, Gadubanud, Gunditijamara, Giriai Wurrung, and Djargurd Wurrong peoples. I pay my respects to their elders past present and emerging. I also acknowledge their ongoing care and custodianship of the nations encompassed by Barwon South West, and the differentiated impacts of climate change for First Nations peoples and their lands, including the loss of sacred sites due to sea level rise.

Introduction

These poems are made from the words of 10 climate governance workers across the Barwon South West region in so-called Victoria, Australia. These people worked mostly in local and state government, helping communities to prepare for and adapt to climate change. I interviewed them about their emotions and relationships to place, and how this entangles with climate change and their work. After each interview, I pulled participants' words from the transcript and converted those words into a poem. Although the poems are crafted by me, they almost exclusively use the words of the participants. When I have inserted my own voice, or edited these words for legibility, it is indicated by the use of square brackets.

Dedication

These poems are dedicated to all people who actively grapple with the troubles of these times, and find the courage to feel what that means, and of course, that includes these participants who so graciously shared their stories with me.

An intellectual exercise

I think the way I deal with [climate change]

is the way I deal with most difficult emotions in my life.

I intellectualise it.

Yeah.

It’s work,

it’s an intellectual exercise,

a problem that needs to be solved.

I’ve dedicated my whole professional life to this.

No, I don’t want to go home

and be reminded of the awful state the world is in.

I don’t know,

I probably have largely avoided it.

But that hasn’t really been

a conscious thing.

[Are you saying you are feeling quite hopeful or confident about the future?]

As of last week, totally cocky about it,

they've gone all the way around the country,

looked at risk with bushfire and with flooding,

and looked at [where I live], and

we are okay.

And, anyway,

there are solutions.

It's not just so totally overwhelming that we just say

"stuff it".

Innovation and technology are part of the solution.

They are trusting it's going to be the total solution,

Yeah, we shouldn't be basing our decisions

on that,

but

it's not totally unrealistic,

knowledge makes the difference.

Assets

Assets.

Multi-million-dollar dwellings.

I get frustrated,

we spend our money trying to protect assets.

The most expensive assets.

I know they're important,

but they're not the be-all and end-all.

When we talk about sea level rise,

and losing intertidal habitat and saltmarsh habitat,

and haven't made any provision for those communities to succeed,

there's either a road, or some sort of development

that has absolutely stopped any chance for those communities

migrating.

Some people call it coastal squeeze.

You're squeezing out marine communities,

squeezing them into extinction.

That can be disturbing,

depressing at times.

We need to look at risk to

actual communities.

human communities,

marine communities,

vulnerable communities,

I see a lot of things differently.

Not what the authorities want necessarily.

We could be doing things differently.

We're not trying new and more innovative ideas.

There's huge opportunity in nature.

But we are stuck with these structures

[these bluestone seawalls],

and we're stuck with them forever,

trying to protect the most expensive

assets.

Collective guilt

I was looking at your questions

[about climate grief]

and

it made me think of

the grief that Traditional Owners must experience.

You know? Like when they see landscapes

really

really

changed.

I've recently heard a talk, from a white person's point of view.

One of the concepts she touched on was white guilt

But her key message was that white people have to get away from their guilt,

because it's just an additional burden Aboriginal people have to shoulder.

And I started thinking about this white guilt.

Now I'm thinking, you know,

with some of the environmental devastation that we're seeing,

there's an element of guilt there as well:

A sort of

collective

cultural

guilt.

“What have we done”

Yeah, we’ve really fucked this place over, you know?

And look, I’ve heard that expressed in different ways by many different people.

That’s pretty sad.

That’s pretty

hard to swallow.

Doom-type perspective, or it’s my job to progress things

There’re those stories that make you feel overwhelmed.

They're always

global-scale,

doom-type

perspective.

It’s like, god,

if the ocean’s die,

you know, how they talk about,

the whole ocean,

the ocean ecosystem,

collapsing.

The whole world just like

ends.

Ends life as we know it.

And so the grief comes.

I was like, oh my god, what happens if

if in like 20 years’ time

the eels,

they can’t migrate anymore?

And it's just like, just got this sense of like

a perpetuating “Oh my god,

what happens if?”.

I pretty quickly pull myself out of it,

knowing that hasn’t happened yet.

I think what I’m trying to say is

I really try to control

my grief.

It’s my job to progress things,

to help people.

And when you are at that

global-scale

you have no control.

Like, humans have no control.

Like, you’re just an animal.

[Do you feel comfortable about what the future might be like?]

Personally [I do],

but not

for

people

who are still around

[when I'm gone].

Yes. There's concern

for

your generation.

[Do you think you accept how things might change?]

I think I’m still in denial.

I don’t really want to think

about the reality

of the degrees going up

and what that's going to mean.

I know what it means, like, rationally. Yeah.

Yeah, I know what it means.

But [emotionally]

I think it's not gonna happen.

I don't really want to sit in that,

I don’t really want to sit in that reality.

Dystopian futures

I mean, I do think about those dystopian futures,

but I’m like, what is that achieving?

Like, taking action is really important.

Just, translating that

despair,

fear, and

concern

into action.

Then just trying to

have some

hope.

[Emotional language]

When you're having a conversation

with a technical expert

it's quite easy to speak that technical language

and have some level of

separation.

When you're having that conversation

with someone emotionally invested in a place

it's nearly impossible

to have that technical conversation.

We're speaking a different language.

We have to try and make

evidence-based decisions

[but] it's also an incomplete knowledge

we have to accept

that technical knowledge is somewhat limited.

And a lot of people get angry with

scientists

and other technical people,

because the

emotional

spiritual

side

isn’t given enough

weight.

Finding your arrangement

Adapting is being willing to consider a new and different approach

it’s being able to look at all your options,

and be somewhat flexible.

Finding your arrangement.

And yeah, sometimes

that can be to do nothing,

and accept that change is occurring.

And yeah, sometimes it might be to intervene,

and do something.

Guilt

I used to feel a lot of guilt. It made it harder to enjoy life. It meant that I deprive myself of things that I want or want to do, because they're not good for the environment.

I reckon anyone with an environmental background probably feels a lot of guilt. Like I certainly feel guilty. That I should be doing more. Yeah, I'm not doing enough. I think I give myself a hard time. But I'm doing it in a safe way, working in the government.

I have let go of a lot of that guilt.

I'm not responsible for solving the *entire* problem.

And when I'm unhappy, I'm less productive. You have to look after yourself, so you have the energy to do stuff you're passionate about.

I'm allowed to consume things and enjoy my life.

I'm allowed to be happy.

[How does it feel to see the new housing estates?]

Yeah, feelings of unease,

it sits uncomfortably for me.

You know, I understand that people need

somewhere to live.

It's affordable.

I have friends that live in those areas.

But

it just doesn't feel

right.

It's uncomfortable.

It does give me a negative feeling.

Because I look at things like that and I think, gosh,

these things happen

so quickly

and destroy

so much

so fast.

We are doing all this work

trying to retain stuff,

look after stuff.

And I think, are these things going to happen quicker, that what we're trying to do?

Feels like, "is it worth it?"

[How do you feel hope?]

I guess the thing is, like,

you're always pushed

to give

hope.

I give a lot of presentations about climate sciences.

Incredibly depressing.

A lot about heatwaves.

And it’s really hard.

I always I feel like I've

depressed people.

And then I've got to give,

give them some hope.

And then I think *why?*

Why do we have to have hope?

You know, is it useful?

Or is it actually counterproductive to hope?

Is hope a reliance on?

Is hope to externalise?

My hope stems from societal change.

But,

now

I have this horrible suspicion

that the proportion of anthropocentric and ecocentric people in the world is kind of set.

I try to [feel hope].

I have to look really hard for it sometimes.

I do try.

I consider myself a hopeful person.

I look for ways to act.

I grieve for the life I thought I would have.

I was doing whale ecology stuff

and we went to Antarctica.

And usually, they get these massive populations of krill

that the whales live on

and they were having trouble finding it.

Anyway, it was a fabulous trip, we saw lots of whales and seals and icebergs.

Amazing

absolutely amazing.

And we came back.

We went up north to the Kimberly

and the Humpback whales were coming back

from Antarctica,

where they feed themselves up

get fat

for the breeding season,

but they were really skinny.

We saw humpback whales where you could see their ribs.

Just

yeah

really

disturbing.

It was a moment for me.

I think because I already had [losing the] saltmarsh stuck in my head

and then the whale experience too.

I saw [a climate change job]

and was like

“okay, yeah”.

And that was that.

I grieve for the life I thought I would have.

I pictured my future, you know,

some kind of lady naturalist.

Just wandering around

looking at nature,

go to wild places,

sketch,

observe.

I grieve for the life I thought I would have.

I've chosen not to have children.

It's the number 1 thing you can do

if you care about the planet.

It's a decision I could make

and I struggled with it

and I do grieve for that.

I grieve for the life I thought I would have.

I grieve for the life I thought I would have.

Because I can’t [have that life].

I have to fight.

Fight

everyday

instead.

I’m not going to run away from it.

My friend, he was like:

“You’ve got to get away,

get away from the coast.”

Tidal waves.

Fires.

He moved inland.

I said,

“Look,

if we get wiped out,

here on the coast,

it’s just life,

you know?”

I’m not going to

run away from it.

[Is that grief?]

Yeah, because

it’s a loss

and

it’s a loss

you can’t

get back.

[Climate grief?]

the word climate is misleading.

it’s not climate,

it’s environmental

it’s caused by several factors.

It’s not balanced anymore,

we’re not addressing it holistically,

You know, in an ideal world,

the marshes would migrate backwards,

[but] they can’t migrate backwards

so, when inundation happens,

we’re going to

lose bits.

All those species that are 100% dependent on it

have nowhere to do.

So, yeah,

you don’t go [to those places]

I don’t go.

It’s just disheartening,

some places can be just soul-destroying.

[And the work?]

It’s draining,

it wears you down.

And the longer it goes, you end up making yourself sick.

I have to walk away.

[Is there an emotional load to the work?]

I don’t doubt there is a load,

an emotional load.

But because we work in it all the time,

it’s like the frog in the pot,

you know, slowly heating up.

The frequency

of extreme events,

the extremity

of extreme events,

It’s not going to be gradual change.

No one wants people to live in

calamity.

It’s like a grief

When I saw what happened in the Grampians

and you know,

to drive through the fire grounds,

that was confronting.

It’s like a grief,

you know,

like when you’ve lost an important person in your life.

That’s what it’s like.

My grief places are the same as my solace places.

I've realised

my grief places are the same as

my solace places.

[The places where]

people have their ashes sprinkled.

[The places where]

people go to to feel connected to something bigger.

I mean you get here

and you can’t wipe the smile off your face even though it’s drizzling.

I don’t want it to stay the same,

it changes,

ecology is all about change and pattern over time.

But

there is grief, because:

It might not function.

It might not provide habitat.

It might end up so degraded

that it doesn’t live and breathe ~~like this does.~~

It's hard to go to the saltmarsh now.

I find it really hard to look at them,

without thinking how they'll be gone

And it really really hurts.

It’s when I’m in my solace places, and

The implications hit me

like, tighten around my heart

You know

They are the grief feelings.

And I look at the landscape,

and I'm moved by the beauty of it,

and I feel it deeply.

But now

there is *always* now

a bit of grief there.

[My kids], they’re so worried.

It’s amazing how much stress these kids have.

You’re trying to manage their fears.

[My daughter is] worried about floods.

She’s worried about bushfires.

When we had bushfires,

we couldn’t leave the house because it was so smoky.

And the beach was closed.

And that makes you worried.

Because [my kids],

they’re so worried.

Our changing vernacular

[I think about] the way that we used to talk half a century ago.

We used to call rainforest jungle.

We used to call woodlands scrub.

We used to call saltmarsh swamp. Really derogatory terms.

The vernacular has changed to make them appear more valued.

But I don’t believe we are enacting that.

I've had the opportunity

and the privilege

to learn a lot about marine and coastal environments.

Yeah. And I really put a lot of value on them.

I place a lot of value on them.

I value them

dearly.

Spectre of disaster

I’m standing in a landscape

looking at the rolling hills

and think “Geez, this place is scary in summer”.

And there’s a few high risk days each year

and on those days you just don’t want to be there.

But there’s gonna be a lot of people.

This whole area relies on tourism.

We can’t shut it down,

nor would you want to

but

[there’s] a sense of foreboding

“This can be a really risky

dangerous

place to be.”

I stand on top of the hill and look out across

the township there and the creek,

and shake my head and think

“Geez, when a fire comes through here it’s gonna be awful.”

but then that gives me the reason I do my job.

The value of seagrass

I love

walking through

and kicking through

kelp

that's washed up on the beach,

and algae, the different species of algae,

and I’m quite passionate about

seagrass.

People think it's a scourge on their beaches,

because it smells,

and it washes up,

and it gets between their toes,

but I see it as an absolute phenomena:

How it comes and goes,

regenerates.

What it does,

when it lumps up on beaches,

is invaluable.

People want it cleaned off the beaches,

even in winter.

I know the value of seagrass though.

[The ocean] is the heart.

If you look at this,

this is no different than a person.

If we think about the planet.

The universe, that's the brains.

[The ocean], is the heart, its pumping life,

up all the streams,

so that's the veins.

It's got kidneys, it's got wetlands

and the kidneys are filtering.

The whole human body is here,

but just in a different form.

That's how I look at it.

You know?

This is the heart.

It's pumping life,

and we keep stuffing it up,

and it's like an old man's heart,

it might stop one day.

Too-hard-basket

[Adaptation] is very easy to put in the too-hard-basket.

We don’t know the answers,

there are so many things about it

that make people feel

scared

uncomfortable

uncertain.

Trying to hold back the ocean

You're constantly trying to hold back the ocean,

which is

of course

not possible,

but you have a community expectation that you will

be able to do this

and stop the beach

changing.

So, every time there's a big swell,

I'm constantly worried:

What's going to erode?

What impacts are we going to have?

And what irate community members am I going to have to face?

I love that the coast always changes.

You might think that you dive one patch of reef

and it's going to be the same over years,

but sand moves out of some holes

and you'll come back two years later

and suddenly there's a big cave there…

I love that it changes.

It’s just that humans have built things

in the way

and those things

fall into the ocean,

and there isn’t that capacity

for nature to regenerate as much anymore.

I love that the coast is dynamic and changing,

the hard bit is:

How [do] we manage the humans?

[And]

Where do the plants go when we retreat inland?

[And]

[There are] cultural heritage sites that are being eroded.

A lot of that connection to Country and culture has been lost.

Middens are falling into the ocean.

We need to see the personal impact

One of the ways I hope is like

when the bushfires were happening in 2020

[it was] obviously awful and devastating

but to me that's an opportunity

because now people will listen to me.

In the month after I can be like:

Look at what happened.

We need to think about this.

It's the same with floods.

Because people don't want to think about this.

Because we aren't wired for dealing with climate change,

we are wired to deal with a tiger in front of us.

Humans need to see,

(me included)

we need to see the

personal impact

before we start taking action.

[What are you trying to do in your job?]

We historically plan for one future.

We never want anything to go wrong.

[Like] we have to build a rock wall around the entire country,

[or] gold plate our infrastructure to operate at 70 degrees.

It's just not gonna happen:

No one is going to pay for it.

I'm more about,

being a bit smarter,

moving from, "We never want this to happen"

to

"What are the multiple futures that could happen?"

We can't stop things from going wrong.

How would we adapt?

It's more of a resilience mindset.

like, it's safe to fail.

[What does adaptation mean to you personally?]

[Adaptation means] simplifying our lives.

It means getting off the treadmill.

Really thinking about some of the things

we've taken for granted for a long, long time.

It means becoming more communal.

Sharing more,

using less.

You know, that’s what it means to me.

[Where do you experience solace?]

I’m gonna be really specific.

It’s where I walk my dog on the beach.

It’s a big wide open beach.

Almost no sign of human impact on the world.

There’s a lighthouse in the distance.

You walk along there,

and it’s just

the sand dunes

and the ocean.

And when it’s crappy weather,

you’ve got it to yourself

and it’s beautiful.

It’s sort of that big thing

that without the human species

life will go on,

That the world is so much bigger

than us.

There’s way more to the world

than us.

We might wreck it for ourselves.

We might have wiped out some amazing species,

but

given enough time

other species will pop up and fill those voids.

And

it might be unrecognizable

but it’s there

and it will continue on.

[Work is the balm that heals grief]

I suppose I’m very aware of climate grief,

but I think I’m protected a bit.

Because I do *work* in this space.

So, it's not as if I feel like I'm helpless.

Like every week, I just feel so privileged

that I can work in climate change adaptation.

Because I know so many people don’t have that ability.

Certainly, before I was working in this space

I remember feeling

really angry

about just like how

there’s so much we know

and just

inaction.

Now that I work in this space,

certainly, the fact that I work

in adaptation,

(it's all about preparing),

has given me such a more positive outlook,

And

so much

more

hope.

There's a lot of good that's happening

and I'm exposed to that.

That makes me feel

far more

positive

about what we are going towards.

It makes me know that we can adapt, and that

we'll

be

okay.